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The Churchill CHRONICLE

Fall Edition

Theatre Calgary of Rashdan Farayazi

Rashdan

If I were the playwright

Isabelle Zhong

The Hamilton Experience

The Jazzmeister

Writing Theme: Under the Spotlight
Design Theme: Gothic

Credits: Pelumi

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Fall Playlist

This fall, take a listen to this edition's playlist, curated by our Chronicle members who have put forward their best work to bring you this edition. A variety of genres, from popular classics like Sweater Weather to new tunes released this year like GGEZ and Wallflower, there's a song for everyone to enjoy.

always
grentperez

Crush
Lesbian Space Princess

Saira & Me
Lesbian Space Princess

GGEZ
Kaien Nuen, SUGAR, M.Sasuke

Long Live (Taylor's Version)
Taylor Swift

Scent Of Love
Helena Noguerra

less
Olivia Rodrigo

peach sand
Strings & Heart

Golden Brown
The Stranglers

Summer
Good Kid

Boom Boom Boom
BOYNEXTDOOR

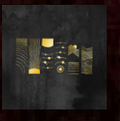
love me now (feat. aria.)
pryme!, aria.

Sweater Weather
The Neighbourhood

Wallflower
Dominic Fike

The Princess and the Clock
Kero Kero Bonito

Eureka Evrika
LUNA GOAMI



North
Sleeping At Last

Photograph by Ringfingerknuckle

Artwork by AZL

THEATRE CALGARY
OF RASHDAN FARAYAZI

BY RASHDAN

Theatre and play production are one of the many ways used to express identity and creativity. In Calgary, we are fortunate to have our own theatre called the Max Bell Theatre. This is where Theatre Calgary performs, one of the city's best professional theatre organizations. The Max Bell Theatre is situated in the Werklund Centre of downtown Calgary, and it allows many writers and directors to share their vision. The origins of Theatre Calgary are also humble and inspiring, showcasing how far dedication to the craft can go.

Bessie Michell, more commonly known as Betty Michell, first immigrated to Oyen, a town in southern Alberta at the age of sixteen. After finishing high school, she attended the Alberta Normal School in Calgary, before teaching at more rural schools to earn tuition to enter the University of Alberta. Eventually, she ended up teaching drama at Western Canada High School, and three of her former students, Kaye Grieve, Betty Valentine, and Frank Glenfield, formed an amateur theatre group called Workshop 14. It was named after the room number in which they held rehearsals, and Michell ended up joining as a director herself upon returning to Calgary after receiving a master's degree from the State University of Iowa in August of 1944. Workshop 14 was regarded as one of the best amateur theatre groups in the country, winning multiple awards in the Dominion Drama Festivals.

The Musicians and Actors Club was housed in the old Isis Movie House, where they would host musical revues and stage short plays. Under the leadership of Kenneth Dyba, the Musicians and Actors Club merged with Workshop 14, to form the group Mac 14 in 1966. This continued until 1968, when, on July 1st, Theatre Calgary was born. It marked the creation of Calgary's first ever professional theatre company. Although Workshop 14 is now historically defunct, it led to the creation of Workshop Theatre, Calgary's longest-running community theatre since 1970.

BY Ringfingerknuckle

Theatre Calgary hosts an array of programs, such as their Creative Learning program to help youth get into theatre. Their TC Learning program allows local and international artists to lead and teach, providing rich learning experiences for those who are interested. Theatre Calgary tickets are also on sale for their upcoming plays. Their October performance was Little Shop of Horrors, a musical which is a blend of comedy, romance, and rock 'n' roll.

There are also upcoming productions for the season, such as A Christmas Carol, which is an adaptation of the Charles Dickens novella. This two-hour play is about Ebenezer Scrooge, who is guided by three spirits through his past, present, and possible future. It will be available from November 26th to December 27th. A brand new play is also in production, planned to run between the 2nd of February and the 21st. Named True West, it plans to explore identity, sibling rivalry, the American dream, and the thin line between order and chaos. All plays are planned to take place in the Max Bell Theatre.

Theatre Calgary acts as a way to experience the arts of Calgary, while also acting as the gateway to opportunities to delve into theatre yourself. With a rich history built on the dedication to the arts, it's a proud staple of Calgary which is worth checking out. For those interested, you can learn more about Theatre Calgary on their official website, theatrecalgary.com.

Written by Isabelle Zhong

If I were the playwright

Of our infinite lives, condensed into
only these five acts, I would
write us a happy ending.

I'd pull out all the stops:
add some cliché trope that would
never happen, not to us,
not in a million years, because
we're too real & alive & flesh-blood
heart beating & cynical for those
make-believe universes
I treat like Eden
and you treat like
fantasy.

(But I write it in anyway,
just to see the look
on your face.)

Or, if saving us through
mortal, believable means
proves far too impossible,
I will, for the first time, play that
one and only trump card:
a deus ex machina, wires & cables & all,
unrealistic but no less absolute
than the real deal.

And if it's too late
to rewrite the entire story
from the beginning, when
you're already at the edge of the stage
going up, hair haloed, back facing me,
getting farther & smaller &
away, away, away—

I will reel you back from
those boiling spotlights,
and we will improvise our own story
out back, in another city, long gone,
in a night that runs hot because of us.
Though this time there is no audience
to sell a stage kiss to,
so you might be able to lean
forward of your own volition &
go off-script & hold me
all lovingly & unrehearsed, and you'll be
real & alive & flesh-blood
heart beating,

able to be contained
in the short distance between
my two arms.

This is the good ending.

By Daisy Q

By Ringfingerknuckle

The Hamilton Experience

BY: THE JAZZMEISTER

How does a concept album from 2009 go on to be one of the most popular musicals worldwide? While I couldn't tell you the specifics, I can tell you that after watching it for myself, I have come to understand the musically magical Broadway phenomenon that is Hamilton. (Psst... to anyone who has already watched it: don't tell me I didn't catch you with that first line!) It took a bit of cajoling from my friend to open up my mind to the musical, but at last I had a day with absolutely nothing to do and, fully expecting a terrible cacophony of overly cringe-worthy puns and mediocre music, I sat down to watch the compiled playlist of the full musical. I don't think I've ever been proven more wrong in my life.

BY: Kaylee Tang

The musical blessing that graced my ears was a far, far cry from anything that I had imagined. Lin-Manuel definitely knew what he was doing with the opening number: Alexander Hamilton, with the rhythms and internal rhyme as well as the narrative choice to have Aaron Burr be the one to introduce our main character, of course: Alexander Hamilton—and from then on, the songs only kept on getting better and better.

Right Hand Man inspired the perfect amount of hype, with war beats and marching rhythms, the build up of this fantastical image of George Washington. Helpless and Satisfied both work together so beautifully, and seeing the two songs side by side made my jaw literally drop at the choreography at work. I think I've fallen in love with Lafayette's rapping in Guns and Ships (which also includes the world record for fastest rapping on Broadway), not to mention Daveed Diggs also playing a very snazzy Thomas Jefferson in What'd I Miss. And of course, no review would be complete without an honourable mention of King George's three songs—all of which my family members now know by heart thanks to my wonderful shower-singing. And these are only some of my favourites—and I assure you, soon these songs will end up taking over your playlist too! My favourite thing besides the music, however, would be the lyricism and the messages throughout the whole musical. It is something to marvel at, how 2 hours and 45 minutes of people dancing and singing on stage could speak volumes about how we should make use of our time, consider the legacy we leave behind, and keep to your passions without throwing away your relationships and family. Undeniably, it's inspiring, and if I had to pick one thing that I found the most profound, it would be what Washington said to Hamilton in Right Hand Man:

"Dying is easy, young man, living is harder."

So, when the next rainy, drab and dreary weekend inevitably arrives, and you find yourself glumly staring out the foggy window, why not instead make yourself a warm, steamy cuppa, settle down on your sofa, and allow yourself to be enthralled by the musical masterpiece that is Hamilton. Who knows? Maybe you'll end up wondering who will live and die and tell your story?

written by Destiney Huang

Spider-Man: Brand New Day

a Closer Look

Areesha

Director: Destin Daniel Cretton
Stars: Tom Holland, Zendaya, Mark Ruffalo, Sadie Sink

Spider-Man: Brand New Day is the world's biggest solo superhero movie so far, breaking chains of global historical records despite only being released in July of this year. Its recognition is not without reason. This movie was very emotionally influential for me as a high school senior struggling with change, the future, and self-expression.

After a long and confusing chain of events from past Spider-Man movies, Peter Parker's friends have lost all memory of him. At the beginning of the movie, he reminisces about his time with his friends and feels conflicted about revealing the truth to them, fearing that his identity as Spider-Man would endanger them. Instead of facing his feelings, he decides to bury them and settle into his role as the friendly neighbourhood Spider-Man. As a result, the movie is packed with action that reflects his internal struggles.

Peter is eventually unable to restrain his curiosity and finds an opportunity to catch up with his ex-best friends, since they had become strangers. During this scene, he learns how they have learned to live without him, which is incredibly traumatic and painful for Peter as he realizes that things will never return to how they used to be. The contrast between the cozy, dimly lit party and the cold, rainy city marks the start of his internal spiral. His intense wrist pain and panicked breathing accurately convey his immense anguish. The close-up shots, flashbacks, dramatic lighting and soundtrack all work together to form an emotional connection between the viewer and Peter as they experience his pain and fears together.

Ringfingerknuckle

Without an emotional outlet, Peter's trauma is released in the form of his arachnid genes, which bring out a faster, stronger, and angrier side of Spider-Man. He tries his hardest to conceal it, believing it is harmful and like a "monster" inside of him. Ironically, Peter forms a solution that would work against both the villain and his own problems. This directly shows how he feels conflicted with himself, actively trying to suppress his feelings the same way he tries to suppress his enemy. As he faces his struggles, Peter learns to acknowledge his bottled-up feelings instead of hiding them and slowly lifts the pressure he puts on himself.

Overall, this film does a beautiful job using Spider-Man's powers and struggles as a reminder of how important it is to love yourself and your differences, and that, even if you feel alone, there are people who will care for you no matter what.

Invisible Artists

Art by Leslie K

Author: Mathew Lo

When we watch a film, we usually focus on the actors, the directors, the costumes, the music—but one person who we often never think about is the editor.

The basic role of the editor is to cut and choose the footage that tells a story. From all the raw footage, film editors assemble all the scenes, making artistic decisions about which ways will work best. Many people working on a film set usually have an idea of what they think the film should look like and how they want to tell the story, from the cinematographers deciding how they can use the camera to affect the visual feel of the film, to the screenwriters deciding the progression of the story, the job of the editor is to take all those ideas and make them into reality.

When the editors receive hundreds of hours of footage, their job is to meticulously compare and select the takes and assemble them into an order that makes sense. This preliminary version is the "assembly cut", which is used as a first rough draft of every usable take from beginning to end. This cut is often much longer than the film's intended runtime, usually two or three times the final length, but it serves as a first step to make sure everyone is happy with all the recorded content. There is often much that is needed to be cut from this rough draft, whether for pacing, narrative, or emotional reasons, the editor's job is to make those cuts while maintaining the fabric of the film.

This is where the cut turns from a series of clips into an actual structured story. Editors create several versions of rough cuts, where they test out different styles or strategies to see which version works best in terms of pacing, continuity, and overall structure. After the broader strokes of the structure have been painted, editors then work on more minor trimming, selecting the best takes, and refining the rhythm of the story. Within the structure of each scene, editors often have a great deal of power in choosing how to manipulate the way they cut between shots and which shots they choose to show, as they play with the cinematic grammar of each scene to shape character and perspective. At this point, editors also work with sound and music, making sure that they have an idea of what harmonizes and goes along with what is visually shown on the screen. Once this is all done, all the frames are locked into place, and the editor's job is done, with the entire cut passed on to sound designers, colourists, and visual effects artists.

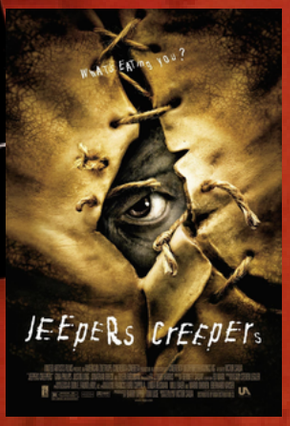
The editor is one of the more invisible parts of every film set, as their job can help refine the imperfections in what is actually recorded into a more coherent and impactful story. Changing which specific shots are shown in each scene or the order of a story can make important changes to the tone, which are invisible to the ordinary viewer when done well. The next time you watch a movie, pay attention to the cuts. Think about how showing the shot of another part of the scene might have altered the story, or how lingering on one particular moment changes the tone. You might just notice how important these unsung heroes are.

The Ultimate Fall Watch List

Written by A.A

Take a break from studying (or watch as you work) with a selection of both popular and semi-niche movie and TV show recommendations that are perfect for the fall season!

Dead Poets Society
(1989)
A fall classic about British boarding school boys and their inspirational teacher who walks them through life. There's no way that you'll cry... totally...



Jeepers Creepers
(2001)
Human harvesting, monsters, and the occasional body dismemberment! Who wouldn't want to watch that?

Weak Hero
(2022)
To everyone who says they don't like K-Dramas: watch this and you're going to realize you've been in denial (canon event).

The Hunger Games: Sunrise on the Reaping
(2026)
Coming out November 20th! Read the book first, or don't... you will cry regardless.

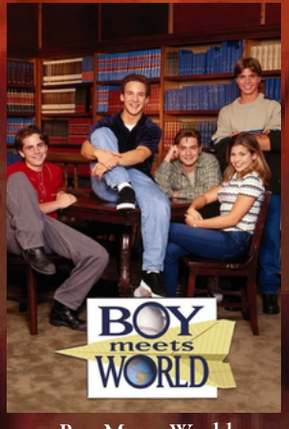
The Maze Runner
(2014)
Sweaty boys running around a maze while the world is ending... 10/10 recommend.

The Intern
(2015)
A little more light and whimsical if you like workplace dramas and Anne Hathaway. (Who doesn't like Anne Hathaway?)

Criminal Minds
(2005-present)
The best crime, thriller, murder, found family, traumatizing show you will ever lay your eyes upon.

Prison Break
(2005)
A guy tattoos the entire map of a penitentiary on his body and commits a crime to save his brother.

Freaky Friday
(2003)
Ever wondered what would happen if your crush had a crush on your mom? Yeah, me too... go watch Freaky Friday!



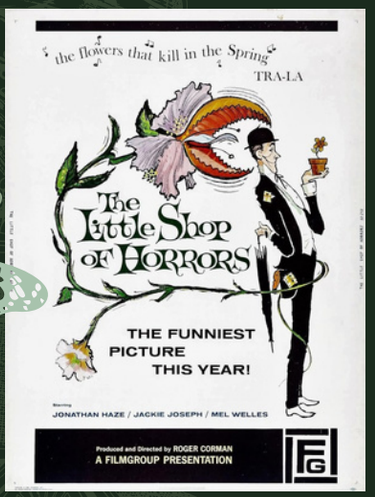
Boy Meets World
(1993)
A must-watch 90s sitcom where you get to watch an innocent 12-year-old boy become an adult menace... you'll love it.

The Judge from Hell
(2024)
A girl in hell is too evil and has to redeem herself on Earth by murdering killers.

School of Rock
(2016)
Is it a really cliche knockoff of the 2003 original movie with Jack Black? Yes! Should you still watch it? Yes.

Upcoming Production

written by Akirausyu



1960

With this fall's theme, 'Under the Spotlight, ' many Broadway shows are happening in Calgary. For those interested in theatre, musicals, and live performances, the upcoming 2026-2027 season has many opportunities to buy tickets for you and your friends to watch the following performances coming to Jubilee.

Little Shop of Horrors is a musical that illustrates how a timid shop assistant discovers a plant with a taste for blood mixed with comedy, romance, and rock 'n' roll. Running from September 25 - October 24 at the Max Bell Theatre at 2:00 pm and 7:30 pm. Tickets sell individually for $70-126.

Beauty and the Beast is one of the upcoming musicals on this list, influenced by the live-action "Beauty and the Beast" theatres such as Jubilee are selling tickets, with the musical playing from November 10-15. Depending on the day, the earliest show time is at 12:00 pm, and the latest is at 7.30 pm. Ticket prices range from $106-$806 depending on the seating when viewing it in theatres.

1991

A Christmas Carol is an adaptation of the Charles Dickens classic, following Ebenezer Scrooge on a Christmas journey as three spirits show him the past, present, and future. Playing from November 26 to December 27 at Max Bell Theatre, its show times range from 11 am to 7:30 pm. The ticket prices, depending on seating, range from $30 to $126 .

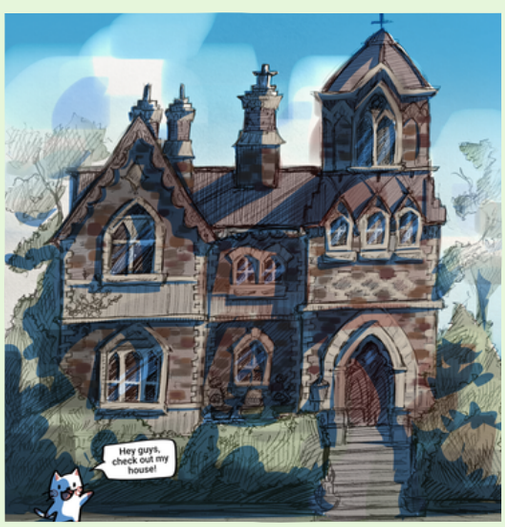
Mrs. Doubtfire is an adaptation of the 1993 comedy-drama film, which follows the story of a recently divorced father who comes up with an idea to dress up as an old Scottish nanny to spend time with his kids while trying to keep his real identity under wraps. Located in the Southern Alberta Jubilee Auditorium, it runs from January 5th -10th, 2027, at 1:00 pm, 2:00 pm, and 7:30 pm. The price ranges from $98-$1232 for each individual ticket depending on seating.

Peter Pan Goes Wrong is another work from the creators of "A Play That Goes Wrong", from May 25 - June 20, 2027, revolving around theatrical disasters while taking flight with Peter Pan. Located at the Max Bell Theatre, with times either at 2:00 pm or 7:30 pm, the ticket prices can range from $55-126.

Hamilton by Lin-Manuel Miranda is set to show on June 15-27 in 2027; its story revolves around one of the founding fathers, Alexander Hamilton, and his role in the American Revolution alongside later chapters of his life. Located in Southern Alberta Jubilee, its times are set either at 1:00 pm or 7:00-7:30 pm throughout June. Due to its popularity, the tickets individually range from $152-$1931 depending on the seating chosen.

2020

Now you know.



by Serena

THE

WRITTEN BY

Released in 2006, and popularized only a couple of years ago, *The Fall* remains one of the most outstanding visual films I have ever seen. A movie beyond its time, and though it was released twenty years ago, the visual storytelling in *The Fall* rivals that of films that came out just this year. Assisted by the incredible cinematography, the plot is what made this movie a true masterpiece. The juxtaposition between the elaborate and vibrant visual storytelling, and the underlying themes of grief and depression make the movie a must-watch.

The Fall was produced, co-written, and directed by Tarsem Singh, who spent nineteen years location scouting for the movie before he even began filming. The movie was shot in twenty-four different countries across the world, with the most notable ones being India, South Africa, and Namibia. Other countries include Turkiye, France, Italy, Fiji, China, Cambodia, Czech Republic, Argentina, Spain, and Indonesia. No CGI or greenscreen were used during production, and every single scene was shot in a real world location with very little set alteration.

The film follows a six year old girl named Alexandria, who is staying in a hospital due to a broken arm. She sustained the injury while picking fruit in an orchard in California, which is where she and her Romanian immigrant family work. In the hospital, she meets a stunt actor named Roy, who became paralyzed after an incident on his set. In the 1920s, when the movie takes place, most people do not have access to movies and films, so Alexandria doesn't exactly understand why he is injured. While Roy recovers in the hospital, his girlfriend leaves him for another actor. This is the movie's inciting incident, and causes Roy to fall into depression and entertain suicidal ideation. Stuck in a hospital bed, he decides he wants to overdose on medication, thus ending his life. However, because he's paralyzed and can't follow through on his own, Roy convinces Alexandria to bring him the medicine in exchange for a story.

This story plays a big part in the visual format of the movie, as it switches between their real world, and Alexandria's perspective within the story. The tale follows a masked bandit, who is also Roy since each character in the story is represented by someone Alexandria knows. The masked bandit teams up with five other men, who are all united under the common goal of defeating their common enemy, a man who has ruined each of their lives, governor Odius. As the story progresses, we begin to see Roy's internal struggles reflected in the masked bandit character. He grapples with his feelings of helplessness in the face of his injuries, and his grief after losing his girlfriend. The five men in the story die one by one in order to get the masked bandit to governor Odius's palace, but when he finally arrives, he finds he cannot defeat him.

FALL (2006)

GRETA BLANTON

Towards the end of the story, Alexandria herself appears as a character — the masked bandit's daughter. This shows how she has begun to view Roy as a father figure, and that despite being young, she knows he is in physical and psychological turmoil and in need of her help. She brings him the medication to make him feel better, but in the process, suffers a head industry falling from a cabinet she was stood upon. When she awakens, Roy is sitting at her bedside waiting for her, where he tells her that the story was all a ploy to get her to bring him medication. His guilt is evident, but so is his care for her. To his relief, Alexandria is not upset. She has grown to love Roy, and she wants him to finish the story regardless.

So we return to Roy's story. When the masked bandit confronts governor Odius, he fails to defeat him. Alexandria's character yells at him to get up and keep fighting. She encourages the bandit–Roy–by telling him that she cares for and needs him. Roy struggles to choose between his depression and his unexpected love for the little girl. She screams, telling the masked bandit that she, his daughter, needs him. Because of this, Roy is finally able to stand back up and defeat governor Odius for good. This is representative of him choosing to live and get better, rather than give in to his struggles. After the end of Roy's story, there is a notable dialogue where Roy tells Alexandria, "We're quite the strange pair, aren't we?" They hug, and Roy wipes away Alexandria's tears. Soon, the two recover from their respective injuries. Alexandria returns to her family at the orchard, and Roy, newly invigorated, goes back to acting.

The final scenes depict many shots from movies in the 1920s, in addition to an unedited cut of Alexandria talking about how much she loves seeing Roy in the movies.

I have watched this film many times over the years, and found that the family storyline never ceases to make me emotional. This movie and its visuals are truly a hidden gem, and it is one film everyone should see at least once. *The Fall* definitely deserves a bigger spotlight and more recognition for being the masterpiece that it is.

TAKEN BY RIMA HAMAMI

Killcrest
Hazard Zone

Unsteady hands sweep down my torn dark grey jeans, as I inhale a shaky breath.

You've got this, Sloane.

My eyes shift to the mirror, searching for anything out of place. My uniform is clean, not a wrinkle on my light blue shirt. I adjust my name tag a little, making sure it's straight as an arrow. After that, I tuck my dark brown ponytail into my slate blue hat, printed with the Mile a Minute logo in blocky black letters.

Before I leave, I pat my pockets, ensuring I have my assigned mail truck keys. Last time I forgot them, Anna made me work the postal counter. It was truly hell.

I turn to say goodbye to my parents, but stop short. The dull silence of the dimly lit space makes me remember—they didn't want me home anymore.

After all, that's why I'm doing this.

The thought clears as I shake my head.

I can't be late.

With one last deep breath, I stride out of my scrappy apartment and begin the long trek to the bus stop.

"Cutting it close, again," Anna scolds when I walk through the door.

"I know, I know, I'm sorry. The bus got stuck in traffic." I sigh, smoothing my hands down my rumpled shirt. Every day, I start out flawless and arrive here mangled. Nothing frustrates me more than that.

"Whatever. Julie says she wants to see you," Anna calls idly over her shoulder as she walks away.

Tension grips my body. I hate talking to Julie. Just the thought makes me start trembling.

I clench my hands to stop the shaking. Slowly, I make my way to her office.

Seconds tick by as I shift around on my feet, giving myself a minute to mentally prepare.

Finally, I knock tentatively.

"Come in," her muffled voice reaches me through the door.

I edge into the room, attempting to keep my voice steady as I say, "You wanted to see me?"

She nods, gesturing to the seat across the desk. Her cold eyes scan over me as I move to the chair. After I sit down, she speaks in a rushed voice.

"Alright Sloane, we don't have time to waste. You said you wanted deliveries with higher pay, right?"

She doesn't wait for me to answer.

"I have a job for you," She hands me a delivery run sheet.

"Deliver these packages to Killcrest Academy in two hours." She pauses a moment before finishing.

"I'll offer you triple the pay."

"Triple?" I choke out. The most I ever got was double, and that was for delivering parcels during a wild snow storm.

"No time to mess around, it's an hour and forty minutes away. Plus, the truck needs to be loaded." Julie waves her hand to dismiss me.

In an instant, I'm on my feet, nearly faceplanting into a wall as I trip out of her office towards the loading bay.

The bustle of the loading dock is overwhelming as I search for what I need.

Suddenly, my eyes fall on a stack labeled 'Killcrest.'

Oh my god. There has to be over 60 packages. Heaving out a breath, I start with the first box, moving as fast as I "That's going to take hours."

I roll my eyes at the comment, lifting another heavy box into the back of my mail truck.

"Then you can help me, Anna," I huff, my eyes skipping to my watch. Only fifteen minutes before I have to get on the road, and I've only done six packages.

"C'mon, I have to get on the road soon! Killcrest Academy is super far away." The annoyance in my voice is clear.

"Wait, wait, Killcrest? Oh man, I'll give a lovely speech at your funeral," Anna remarks solemnly, causing my panic to spike.

"What are you talking about?" A lump snags in my throat, my movements growing rigid as I haul another few boxes into the back.

"Oh my god, everyone who gets assigned to that place goes crazy! No one will even talk about it, that's how bad it is!" Anna shudders a little, before beginning to help me load up the truck.

"I'm sure that's an exaggeration." I try to laugh, but my throat is tight.

"I guess you'll find out soon enough. Just don't start screaming about flying eyes or any nonsense like that." Anna chuckles lightly and I give a half-hearted puff of air.

Something inside of me screams: this has to be a mistake.

Academy

Author: Lyric Blackthorn

Kaylee Tang

The gates of Killcrest Academy come into view, causing me to drop my speed into a slow crawl.

This area is cloudy, only occasionally does sunlight slip through the grey mass.

I pull right up to the gates, staring in awe at the beautiful stone building looming over me. A large tower stands taller than all the rest where a huge brass bell hangs in the worn stone building. A set of stairs leads to a pair of wooden doors with a brass knocker just barely clinging on.

Dozens of windows are all lined up in perfect order. Though it appears the glass is dirty, it's difficult to be certain from my distance.

I wait a moment to see if anyone is going to let me in, but nope. I suppose life isn't that easy.

The cool metal of the door handle in my grasp grounds me, clarifying that Anna was joking, and there will, in fact, be no flying eyes.

With a few aggressive shoves, the creaky gates open just enough for my truck to get through.

A strong wind whips violently at me, causing a shiver to crawl down my spine, prompting me to rush back into the safety of my truck.

Once inside, I exhale a sigh of temporary relief. This place gives me the creeps.

Checking the directions one more time, I drive through the gates.

Fog lurks around the school grounds, as if ready to swallow trespassers whole.

My grip on the steering wheel tightens as I pull around into a thin alley with a large sign that reads, "Library."

The instructions said to leave the packages at the east library back entrance, so I assume this must be right.

The engine cuts off as I turn the key; the stifling silence is unsettling.

I reach for the door handle, but a sudden rattling sound makes me freeze.

My eyes shoot to the rearview mirror, but only my dark grey eyes are reflected. When I spin around to check, there is nothing there.

Sloane, you are being ridiculous. The world is not out to get you.

Something I have to remind myself of often when my mind spirals.

Instead of dwelling on it, I exit my mail truck and go around to open the back. The damp smell of rain lingers in the air.

A sigh of relief exits my body when I see everything is still fastened in place. I try to get the boxes out of the truck as quickly as possible, but it's a slow process.

Bit by bit, I unload each box, dropping them beside the door. I wonder how many books are in each box for them to be this heavy.

My boots scrape against the stone ground as I move, the eerie sound bouncing off the thin alley walls, solidifying just how alone I am. Sudden thoughts make me shudder, almost as much as the delusion that there's something out here.

As I reach for a particularly large package, I swear it trembles a little. *What the hell?*

Cautiously, I lift the box gently, but this time I'm certain it moved, because there is a loud thump, and the box jolts to the side.

My heart picks up pace, hammering against my ribcage. Another thump, louder, more aggressive.

Nerves spark alive, fear rushing through my veins as my fingers tighten around the cargo.

One final thrash, and the box slips from my hands, crashing to the ground.

It bursts open, metal clinking against the cobblestones.

Whatever is in there violently slams against its confines, hidden by the cardboard box. Then...a snap.

Low hissing echoes around the empty space, followed by the groan of metal bending apart.

I hold my breath, my stomach in knots as the creature emerges, ever so slowly...

Written by Rachel W.

The Intention

Have you ever been put on the spot? Have you ever thought through your words so carefully before you spoke, yet you could never be satisfied with how they came out? Have you ever trembled in front of an audience?

Art by Grace

Have you ever fumbled your words on stage during an important presentation that could determine your grade for the whole term? Or perhaps stood in front of a panel of judges during an audition? Or have you simply sat amongst a group of people who you know judge you inside and out?

Perhaps what first came to mind is the discomfort that sits in your stomach as you're forced to recognise the anxiety sneaking its way into the conversation. Or perhaps there is something beyond the sweaty palms of your hands or the forced smile on your face.

Have you ever noticed the quiet scribbles of your teacher's pen on a mark sheet that completely distracted your mind? Have you ever messed up your performance because of the slightest left and right motion of the judge's head? Was that a shake of disapproval? Have you ever picked up on the grin that crept up someone's face as they exchanged a look with their best friend just as you started talking? Was that real or simply in your head?

Perhaps it's doubting the intention behind the raising of an eyebrow, an expressionless face, or the sneer that you couldn't even prove you saw.

What do we title that feeling? Academic pressure? Performance anxiety? Or peer pressure? No. No. Those are not fitting enough. Nothing captures the moment of panic as you search for an answer to uncertainty.

Was it the doubt that lies behind the wordless attitude of the person who stood across from you? Or was it merely a reflection of your own doubt in yourself that mirrored just the same?

More Than What You See:
The People Behind the Curtain

By Siddharth Bhalla

The lights begin to dim. Conversations across the audience fade into a deafening silence. A spotlight appears on the stage, and suddenly, everyone is watching.

For an audience, a theatrical production begins when the curtain rises. In reality, countless hours of work have already gone into the performance, through the effort put in behind the scenes. In addition to actors, there are the directors, stage crew, costume designers, lighting technicians and many others who work tirelessly behind the sets to create the few hours the audience sees.

Being on stage is often considered the center of theatre, and is treated as such. Performers memorize lines, learn gestures, and practice their characters until it feels natural. However, performing live in front of a large audience also comes with pressure. A missed line, forgotten movement or an unexpected problem can happen at any moment, and performers are forced to graciously continue without letting the audience notice their flaws.

Despite this pressure, and while actors receive most of the attention, a production would not be possible without the people behind the curtain. Stage crew members move props, prepare sets and make sure everything is in the right place at the right time. Lighting and sound also help create the mood and tone of each scene. Even the slightest change can make a moment feel completely different, or out of place.

Costumes and props are another important part of bringing a production to life. They help transform an ordinary stage into another world and allow performers to immerse themselves in their characters. Although these details may only receive a few seconds of attention from the audience, they take hours of planning.

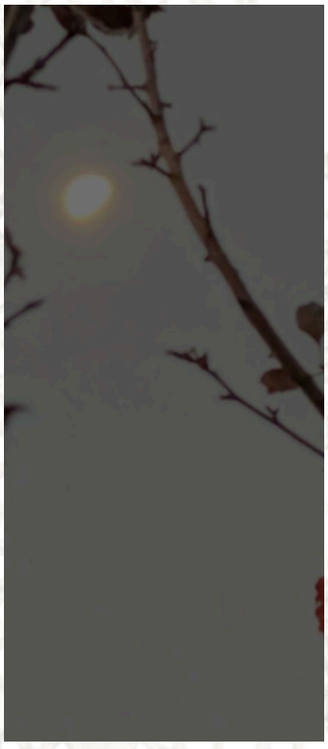
The director and crew bring all these elements to life. Actors, crew members and designers must work as a team under and with the director to create one complete, cohesive performance. Theatre is therefore not just about the person standing beneath the spotlight, but about everyone working toward the same goal.

The pressure persists once the curtain opens. Unlike a movie, a live performance cannot simply be paused and edited when something goes wrong. In the event of an unexpected problem, the performers have to stay in character while the cast and crew work together to react quickly.

When the final scene ends, the audience has seen only the finished product. They may remember the actors, the storyline or the message, but they may not notice the people backstage who moved the props, changed the lighting, adjusted costumes and prepared for the next scene.

The spotlight may belong to the performers, but it takes an entire team to make that spotlight shine.

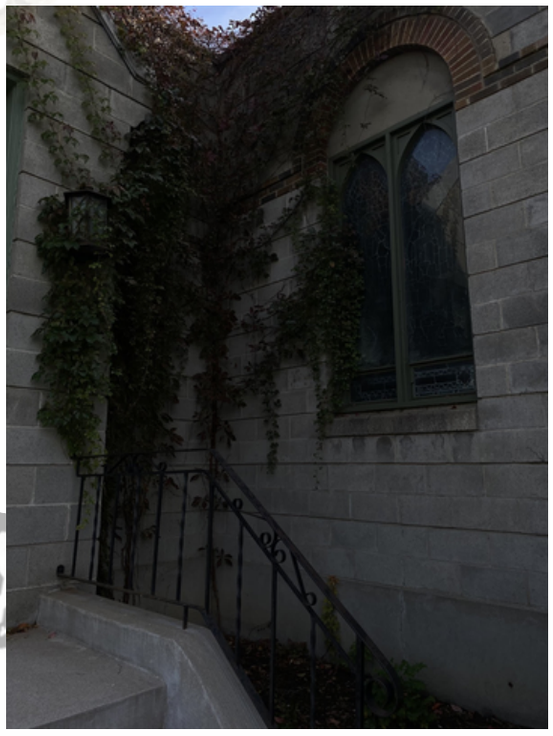
Photo by Sophie



The Birds Who Stay

Written by Lovita Ea

Depending on when this edition is published, many of the birds that were abundant in their voices over the summer may have left. Many finches and sparrows have already marked their leave mid-September, and by November's end, most of the waterfowl species (geese, ducks and swans) will have also left. As the snow starts to fall, and winter becomes apparent, most people believe that the only birds that really stay are the ravens, crows, and magpies. In reality, there are many different species who still call the snow-fallen Calgary home, and as I list just a few of them to you, I hope that you can appreciate the wildlife of the city just a little more, and listen for those bittersweet songs the next time you walk to school.



Black-Capped Chickadee:

One of the most commonly sighted birds throughout the city, they are usually just slightly larger than the size of your fist, with a white belly and a black head with a white stripe. In the winter, they frequently make visits to bird feeders, so don't think of putting yours away. And they have a distinct call, often interpreted in text as chickadee-dee-dee, or feebee. If you see one with a brown cap, that is actually their rarer cousin, the Boreal Chickadee, which is a lucky find to spot within city bounds.

Photo Credits: Aisha Hussain & Sophie

Northern Flicker:

Usually a migratory bird, a few will decide to stay over the winter period. They are larger than a robin, and have spotted orange bellies, striped gray backs, and a red or yellow crown and throat depending on the sub-species. Their call is easily identified as a wick wick wick. They spend a lot of time on the ground or in the trees looking for insects, and are usually solitary birds.

Common Goldeneye:

A medium-sized duck, it is known for its striking yellow eyes that surround a black/brown head and gray and white plumage. They are often found near ponds and creeks, and will stay as long as open water is available. Their nests, meanwhile, are up in the trees, and the females, in particular, have a strong sense of territory, preventing all from entering her waters and nesting area apart from the male she wants. Apart from their voice, which occurs only during mating and brooding seasons, they have a distinct whistling sound when they fly, caused by their unique wingbeat.

Red/White-Breasted Nuthatch:

In similar size to the Chickadees are the Nuthatches, who are easily identifiable from their behavior of feeding upside down in order to get the food that other birds have missed. They attach themselves to coniferous trees, and are also big consumers of bird feeders. They have beautiful ocean-blue backs and wings, and striped black and white crowns. The species is then identified by the color of their belly: a faded red/orange or a snow-white. Their songs are short for the white-breasted, and long for the red, interpreted as a wha-wha-wha, though that is stretching it.

Lost in a Haze

Written by Luna Tekie

Leaves crunch underneath my feet with each step I take. Thousands of them, dripping in hues of gold and red surround my feet. Grey clouds above contrast the halos of color beneath me, as if painted across a canvas. Rain drenches me, doing nothing to soothe the chill creeping down my spine. The wind howls, leaves circle me as I fall onto the cold damp ground. Frigid air sends goosebumps up my skin, hair sticking up erect along my arm. Dead leaves and blades of grass prickle against my fingertips as I look down the hill.

My phone buzzes in my back pocket as a fly buzzes incessantly in my ear. I bring my hand up to swat at it, but end up deciding against it. My phone would continue to buzz and the rain would continue to pour. The phone calls and texts were persistent, until, they just stopped. It would be hours before I got up—or maybe it was just a few minutes? Time seems to pass me in a never-ending haze, messing with my senses.

When I look at the misty haze between the trees, I am not sure what I am seeing. I think I can hear a slow rhythmic groaning beneath me, or maybe I'm imagining that? It feels as though the earth is breathing beneath me, opening up like an old abandoned house revealing its decaying insides. The wind is the cause of the shivers that rake the earth, making her tremble and shake. Yet the rain continues to wash away the debris and dirt, relieving a heavy heart similar to my own.

I touch my face and pull back to see black mascara streaks, the rain causing black rivers to flow down my face. I let out a shaky exhale, wiping my face with my torn sweater. The wind sends my hair cascading through the air, broken branches getting caught in its endless black spirals.

I'm all alone when I hear laughter echoing through the wind. I can't recall what happens next, I try and try to remember but it's as though a part of my memory has been stolen from me. One moment, I'm there in that field staring up at grey skies, soaked to the bone.

Then next thing I know, I'm back in my room and my mom's calling me down for dinner.

Photographs by Kaylee Tang

Movie Reviews

Written by : Cadence Wong

Hotel Transylvania (2012)

Hotel Transylvania doesn't necessarily count as a horror movie, but it is arguably one of the better movies to watch during Halloween season. Yes, it is a child's movie, but don't worry about that. Re-watching Hotel Transylvania, and even its sequels (not including number four) feels like coming home to a familiar meal. No matter your age, it will not fail to make you laugh. Hotel Transylvania, which stars a vampire named (infamously) Dracula and his posse of other eccentric monsters, peacefully live in their hotel (appropriately named Transylvania. This all changes when a human (gasp!) shows up. What follows is a comedic back and forth between hilarious characters and even funnier conversations. What can I say? You just have to watch it. Also, Dracula is voiced by Adam Sandler.

Final review: 9.7/10

Hotel Transylvania (2012)

Smile (2022)

Smile was the first horror movie I watched. Rumored to be a notoriously jumpscare-inducing film, my friend and I had front row seats to a fast-paced thriller. We watched Smile in thirty-minute sessions on the bus, making the movie seem much longer. Nevertheless, psychiatrist Rose Cotter's depressing descent into madness was an attention-grabbing watch. Elements of mystery in Cotter's investigation throughout the film provide a reliable plot amidst the curse-related chaos. Just like any good horror movie, Smile's producers did an excellent job of jumpscaring foolish viewers (including myself) by surprising them during less suspenseful scenes. I'm glad that Cotter tried to solve her problems (tried), despite the other stupid characters that stopped her from doing so. All in all: if you are a horror movie enthusiast, this isn't anything special, but is a relatively decent watch. If you're like me, and you don't really watch horror movies at all, go ahead and look for another.

Final review: 7.3/10

Smile(2022)

Weapons (2025)

The first time I had heard of the movie, Weapons, was from a billboard in New York City, and after watching the trailer, my friends and I were intrigued by its mysterious premise. A bunch of kids randomly leave their homes at 2:17 AM and never come back...except for one. Seems like a good movie, right? You couldn't be more wrong. Despite what its misleading online reviews claim, Weapons is a terrible movie — here's why. The first thirty minutes are excellent. They heighten the mood, they bring mystery, and the build-up makes you want to keep watching. However, after you find out what the huge "dramatic" plot twist is, which is a hot, steamy pile of rubbish, it all goes downhill from there. There is no ingenious maniacal scheme; just a weird old lady that doesn't exactly fit in the plot whatsoever. Honestly, a thirteen year old writing on Wattpad could have written a story with a better plot than this. By the end of your undoubtedly abysmal watching experience, you will find that you have just wasted two hours of your life. Please do not watch this movie! I do not recommend it at all, unless you've got some time to waste.

Final review: 3/10

Weapons(2025)

Phtotgraphed by: Edwin Lu

Hidden Calgary Fall Gem: The Harry Potter House

Written by: Mannat. M

Location: 2820 and 2824 Oak Wood Drive, SW, Calgary
Visiting Date:
October 31 (6:00PM-9:00PM)

My fellow-Potterheads, have you ever wished to live in the wizarding world? And for my Churchill citizens who aren't Potterheads, have you been wondering what activities to partake in to tap into the spooky fall season while still being budget friendly? Well, save the date and tell the other muggles that I have the perfect experience for you!

Ringfingerknuckle

This October, fall in love with the magical world of Hogwarts all over again. Not through another movie marathon or simply through imagination, but by stepping into the magic, and living your inner wizard's dreams in real life.

Two lovely families in Oakridge have teamed up to create this magical experience for Harry Potter fans of all ages. For free! This is their sixth year casting a spell and enchanting Calgarians with this wizarding celebration, and it may be their most magical one yet.

Anisa Kazi

They have worked vigorously over the last six years pouring countless hours to make this dream come to life through thrifting, DIY craft, and much love and support from their families and we Calgarians.

For my non-Potterheads. Don't worry! You don't need to know every spell, recognise the characters or watch all eight movies to enjoy the experience. Whether you are a die hard fan or just discovering this new world, they have something magical for everyone. The houses have been transformed into a full-fledged wizarding world, filled with realistic decor, Instagram-worthy photo options, and multiple optical illusions, which are eye-catching to all.

And the magic doesn't stop there! You can use this enchanting adventure as a chance to give back to our community. Visitors are encouraged to bring non-perishable food donations for the Calgary Food Bank, helping spread a little real life magic to those who need it most.

So grab your robes, dust off your wands, gather your fellow potterheads, summon your brooms, and prepare for a spellbinding fall experience you won't want to miss!

Find more information about this event on their Instagram Profile **@hphalloweenyyc.**

Accio October!

YOU'RE ACTUALLY QUITE IRRELEVANT

In the middle of your presentation, your voice cracked. After you're done, you awkwardly maneuver back to your seat. That evening, that mistake was all you could think about, about how your teacher's going to dock points off, how your classmates will look at you the next day, how you will be reminded of your comically sad blunder and how they burst into laughter. But ultimately, you "crashed out" for nothing because everybody moved on to things that attracted more of their attention, like the latest conspiracy theories or performative trends. Your pointless worrying is a manifestation of the spotlight effect - it is a phenomenon in which people overestimate the extent in which they are being noticed. And though it may hurt some to hear that they are irrelevant to others and that you do not have as big of an impact as you thought you have, it can be a good thing. It prevents us from being put into a chokehold where our expressions get scrutinized to the point where restriction of what makes us humans becomes preferred.

By: Grace Lo

By : Elaine Thomson

How older films are able to stay relevant in modern cinema

Whiplash

by apple mints

Heer Prajapati

In a day and age where the quality of multiple films that have been streaming have been nothing but pleasing to watch and reflect on, it could also be beneficial to look back on some older movies and appreciate the effort that was put into both the concept-building and filming even when the bar of 'visionary' was set lower in comparison to now.

"Whiplash" was officially released more than twelve years ago in 2014, originally starting out as a short film with arguably one of the movie's most iconic scenes. The movie was directed by Damien Chazelle, starring Miles Teller as Andrew Neiman and J.K. Simmons as Terence Fletcher. Despite having a budget of $3 million, its worldwide revenue totaled over $50 million-which always seems to be a recurring pattern with "well-made" films that start with humble finances.

The plot follows an aspiring jazz drummer (Andrew Neiman), his experiences with a ruthless and unorthodox instructor (Terence Fletcher), and how it subsequently changes his life dramatically. Neiman catches Fletcher's eye and is invited to play as a backup drummer. He does everything in his power to make it to the top even if he had some awareness of Fletcher's abuse in the process. Throughout the entire runtime, the viewer is able to pick up more and more of Neiman's internal flaws being forced out as Fletcher continuously places him in extreme situations. Fletcher's multi-layered methods of emotional manipulation and control, paired with his unpredictability, also strongly executes a tense psychological factor that keeps the audience afraid as long as he is present.

Whiplash" is a strong portrayal of how passion can easily descend into desperate obsession and self-destruction if emotional pressure and commitment is left unchecked. It also sets up great characterization and inherently unavoidable suffering for egotistical people that also happen to be constantly envious of the people around them. Even assessing the film from a surface level, it could be considered relevant with the music industry and jazz in particular-other than the irony with how jazz is meant to be one of the most flexible and subjective music forms against the entire plot.

As terrifying as this 106-minute movie was for me on my first watch, I absolutely adored it since then and have rewatched it on multiple occasions during my free time simply because of how unique the entire premise and plot structure feels. Not only is the soundtrack-especially the two mainly performed songs "Whiplash" and "Caravan"-incredibly pleasing to listen to, but the camera work and color grading are also done splendidly when it came to assisting with the environment-building and pacing. The acting is amazingly realistic for a story with so many high stakes, and I was absolutely relieved when I found out that the film won multiple awards for the different aspects.

"Whiplash" is recognized as an influential and modern classic of the 21st century by many, and can be an interesting addition to your "Watch Next" list of emerging cinema. However, for any teachers or anyone interested in pursuing teaching in the future, I highly suggest against hurling a chair at the head of the student that you want to push to be the best version of themselves.

Absolute Cinema

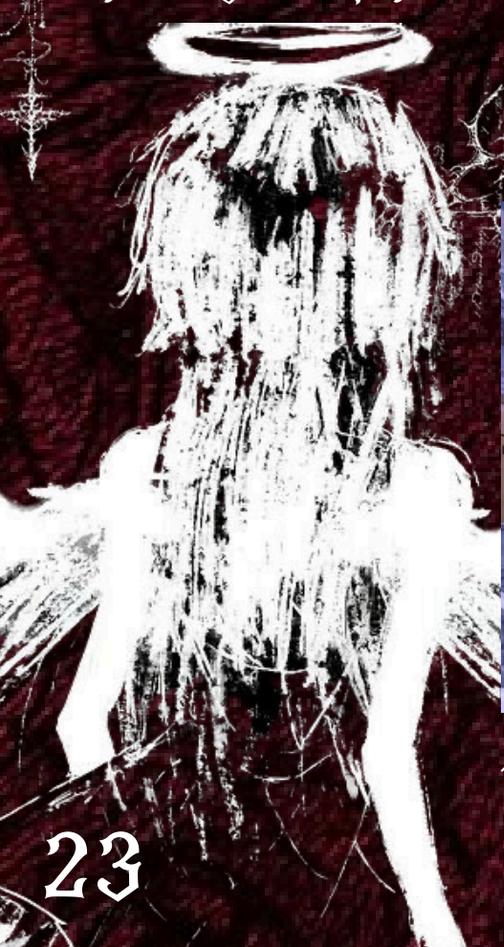
Written by Aiden Xiong

For three days and nights, the month had so far been stale
But on the fourth day, the Holy Grail had been unveiled.
A piece of cinema that will be spoken about for years.
A piece of art that will dictate the course of the years.

Blank, blocky April day, but the evening had come
Finally, it was my turn to engage and entertain from
What fellow critics had glazed so highly about
I step into the dark room with a mind so devout.

Thunderous applause and fervorous cheers galore
Whenever the big blue man spoke a line heard before.
Especially when he yearned for mines or entered the Nether.
Or faced a chicken jockey, that felt like forever.

I step out of the cinema, step into the night.
The lights, the sight, still in my mind with might.
And I think to myself with truth, with strife:
That was genuinely the worst movie I have ever watched in my entire life.



By Carolyn G.

Escape

By Sarah A

By Sophie

Glass doors swing open and
Stop.
A long line awaits you,
At the end of which lives
Buttery sweetness.
You grab your popcorn, your drink, and walk.
At the entrance of the theatre, an idle employee stands.
They scan your ticket, something mindless about the gesture
BEEP.
You nod, and walk,
Into the darkness
Your eyes struggle to adjust
Stumbling, tripping, you shine your flashlight at seat numbers,
Looking for your own.
A hundred "sorries" and "excuse mes"
Finally sitting.
In the cramped seat, two strangers on either side
But it is ok.
Because the moment the screen lights and speakers blare,
You are out of this world.
You have escaped.
A sudden bright glow forces your eyes to adjust yet again
Like an angel descending from the sky
It is only the ads, but your attention is glued
With each passing frame, a train,
Carrying your attention away from the world and into a story
Enthralled, immersed, captivated
You do not think anymore,
You only see
What the story presents
You feel what the characters feel, nothing else
Your worries, fears, stress,
Gone.
And though it does not last,
Though it is not forever
At least it is there.
It is a break from this world
From thoughts, feelings, people
Escape.

Artist: Miriku

Carolyn G.

Kaylee Nham

areesha

Kaylee Nham

2026 Fall Edition

Rima Hammami

Churchill Chronicle Photo Museum

Rima Hammami

Rowan Lily

A Midnight Drive Down the Highway

areesha

Open Submissions

areesha

Carolyn G.

S. Ahmed

areesha

Credits: Pelumi